Ronald Reagan Hates Your Ugly Mother

By Carl Sasoon

The woman is in her mid-twenties or so, verbal, a crowd-pleaser and trying desperately to be funny. Her speech and body are characterized by Tourette's Disorder- her speech is interrupted by vocal tics as indicated by bold italics. She is often plagued by motor tics as well, eye blinking, and uncontrollable head, shoulder, hand and body movements.

WOMAN: Okay, nice crowd. Full house, it looks like. And I'm sure that you're all ready to laugh, which is good news, because I'm pretty funny . . . looking. Ha. Okay. Don't hold back on my account.

See, the first time I went in to see a psychiatrist, I told him, "Doctor, I am so depressed and lonely. No one will talk to me, everyone just runs away because I'm so funny looking. Can you help me?" And he says, "Sure I can! Just come over to this coach and lie face down. Okay. Problem solved."

So, a few weeks later I call him back up because I'm really worried about my daughter, right? And so he tells me to stop stressing out so much and he puts me on tranquilizers. I go back in to see him a couple of weeks later and I tell him that I'm feeling much better. Much calmer. And he says, "How's your daughter?" And I say, Who cares?"

Two guys walk into a bar and ***there's maggots crawling through your filthy brain.*** Two guys walk into a bar and one ***giddy-up, giddy-up, giddy-up!*** Ahh . . . that joke wasn't very funny. I never get to the punchline anyway.

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INTRODUCTION

Tourette syndrome is a condition that affects the brain and nerves, causing people to make repeated movements and sounds that they cannot control. The symptoms usually begin in childhood and will normally become less severe as one enters adulthood. But in 10-15% of cases, the tics become even worse. These attacks can be severe, disabling and last from 15 minutes to several hours. And those minutes can change your life.

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WOMAN: So, here's the thing. You can't take it personally. With Tourette's, the tics just come out of nowhere, anytime, anyplace, anywhere ... with anyone. So, even if I happen to call you "the son of a bleeding donkey" or a "toilet licker," well, it's not you, it's me. It really is. The "toilet licker" one came out about twenty-five times the very first time I met my mother-in-law.

Tourette's. Not responsible. It's not like I even have to plan a whole evening of jokes, because I can be really funny without even trying. People don't really understand Tourette's Syndrome. That's the problem. They think it's some crazy on the bus who screams four-letter words all day long, uncontrollably. Actually, you scream and whisper and shout all kinds of things all day long. And, as an extra bonus, your body freaks out and does weird crap all the time. And- wait for it- there's no cure! Nice. Really, nice.

They say that as many as three percent of the world's population may have Tourette's, which I find really strange, because the other ninety-seven percent is sure a whole lot of people. I feel like I've met a lot of people, but, let me tell you, that three percent, they must all be hiding or something. Any of you? Huh? Sir, you look like you ***gremlins crap on the heads of broken grandmas, bozo-breath,*** might be a three-percenter, you think?

My husband was definitely part of the ninety-seven percent. Yes, past tense.

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Was. No, he's not dead. When he told me that he was leaving me, I said, ***"Julius Caesar pasted wall-paper to your brain",*** and he said . . . nothing, for quite a while. He was just very quiet. We sat there in the silence in the dark and, uh, I was really grateful for our refrigerator, of all things. Because instead of listening to that awful sound of the silence, I listened to the damn humming of that refrigerator. And it was comforting. ***Coldness comes in like black death and vomit.*** And when I started to cry, I turned away from him, because I did not want him to see. And when he did speak he talked a lot about how hard he had tried and that it wasn't that he didn't love me, and I guess, it just sounded like a lot of nonsense to me. Is that selfish? I don't mean it to be. Because, if he was trying, then what did he think I was spending every moment ***crayons are so delicious in the summertime*** of my life doing? Trying to control...this. You spend your life trying. You do. And you just can't run fast enough to get out in front of it. It always wins. And I just kept listening to that damn refrigerator and he just kept talking. He did say that he would "allow" me to see my daughter. That was how he said it. "Allow me." How kind of him.

Sorry. This has been a real downer. So, another guy goes to the psychiatrist and he says, "My wife thinks she's a chicken. Can you help us?" And the Psychiatrist asks how long this has been going on. And the man says, "About two years." And the Psychiatrist asks why it's taken them so long to get help. And the man just shrugs and says, "We needed the eggs." Chicken? Eggs? The woman .. ***headlights take you straight to hell. The headlights take you straight to hell. Hell to headlights. Headlights. Headlights. No no no no no no no no. Old MacDonald had a farm and then he goes to outer space and eats all of Aunt Edna like a gummy bear. No no no no no.*** They call that a . . . fit. A tic fit. Hysterical, huh? It's like your body gets stuck and the tic just replays on a loop. It's like

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you're trapped. Watching yourself from the outside or something but you cannot stop. That was a short one. They can last fifteen minutes. An hour, even. I'm on a medication that's supposed to help control them, make them less severe.

So, uh, my daughter. She's wonderful. Just wonderful, really. So healthy, so . . . well. She was the one who told me that it was okay to laugh about my "oogly booglies." That's what she named them and I just thought that was so cute, you know? And I just thought that for a six-year-old to have that sort of maturity ***my little pony rides off into the sunset and then you'll go to sleep forever*** and awareness. And so, you see, being a mother is everything to me. Because it meant I could be normal. I could be part of the ninety-seven percent. It didn't matter that the rest of the world thought I was crazy, because I had someone who needed me. . . who loved me and wouldn't leave me.

And, you see, I had been doing so well. I hadn't had a fit in . . . months, probably. The new medication was working and uh, she had been with me for the weekend. I didn't usually drive her, but my, ex-husband had a flat tire, and I was doing so well, I mean I had been driving again, for months, you see and it wasn't far. This was last winter and the weather was awful ***Peter Piper is an ugly son of a serial killer*** and I was nervous, but I knew that I could do it. I knew it would be just fine. We were about half-way there when I felt it coming. Like feeling a sneeze that's corning, I think, or an itch that you have to scratch or you'll just go crazy. And so, I pulled over, onto the side, like I know to do, and my daughter, she knew too. She said, "Mommy, the oogly booglies are corning. I love you."

And, you see, I had a fit. A very bad ***you should choke a chicken with a death hammer*** fit. And it just kept going, like it was going to last forever. And she

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was watching me, my daughter was. And I could see in her eyes how scared she was, me screaming and my body flailing around like that, but I could not help myself. I could not stop. And, uh, so, she told me she was going to get help, that we needed help and I was shaking my head as best as I could, but I watched her, like I was paralyzed, and I watched her hand open the door handle of the car and I watched her get out, and I could not stop her, I couldn't, I would have, ***dumb little bumblebee, stings you in your black heart,*** you know that I would have, but, uh, the car did not see her. Couldn't see her in the dark, with the snow.

And my fit ended, and she was lying there so still. And I held her, and I sang to her, just like I did every night. Because we were just like normal people when I sang to her and I would make everything alright. Everything would be just fine. "Hush little baby, don't say a word. Mama's gonna buy you a mockingbird. And if that mockingbird won't sing ... " But everything was not fine. And there was so much blood. And they had to pull me away from her. I would not let her go. I had to tell her that I loved her. That she was my little girl. That I would love her forever. Did she know that?

You don't ever stop being a mother. Not ever.

In case it's escaped you, which is totally possible, given that you're all crazy, this isn't a comedy club. Maybe you've noticed that we're all wearing hospital gowns, we're surrounded by nurses . . . Or . . . the doors are locked. We can't leave. None of us can leave. That's okay, though . . . ***Old MacDonald had a loony bin and now he's got your sister's number.*** At least I know that I belong here. This is where I deserve to be.

I'm never leaving here because I can't get well. I don't want to leave here, and I won't. No one is safe around me. Not really safe, you know? But sometimes,

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I think, you get a do-over. You get a chance to make a "wrong," "right." Do you know what I mean? ***Ronald Reagan hates your ugly mother.*** And this time, I'm going to be perfect. I am.

They've told me that I'm going to get to see her, in here. It's like my daughter's corning back. My husband, ex-husband, whatever, he says that he'll come too. And I'm going to keep them safe from the oogly booglies. I am. ***Tick tock tick tock tick tock out of time sucker.*** I am going to do it all right this time. "Hush little baby, don't say a word..."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
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